

# Ninja Van — Recruiter Screen Prep

Call with **Tripti (Technical Recruiter)** · Full Stack Developer, India Tech Lab · Covers:  
culture fit · motivations · role & Ninja Van · salary expectations

Prep for Priyanka Chatterjee · compiled 2026-07-15

**How to use:** This round filters ~70% of candidates on **communication & culture** — Tripti isn't grading algorithms. Keep every answer **30–60 seconds**, warm and clear. **Internalize, don't memorize** — say these in your own words or they sound canned.

**Status:** you're **available to join immediately** — state that clearly; for a founding team that wants to move fast, it's a real plus. The "why I left Turbot" line below uses a neutral, forward-looking frame (it asserts no specific reason) — if Tripti asks point-blank, give the real reason plainly, then pivot forward to the founding-team draw.

## 1) Culture fit

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**Likely:** "Tell me about your working style." · "What environment do you thrive in?" · "How do you handle ambiguity?"

"I do my best work in fast-moving, high-ownership environments where I'm trusted to figure things out rather than wait for instructions. At Turbot I was fully remote and joined knowing very little Go, SQL, or public cloud — within months I was shipping production Go microservices, and I became one of the top contributors across our four open-source products, 120+ merged PRs. A lot of that came from initiative: when AI coding tools started maturing, I taught myself to use them for our workflows and then ran sessions to help the rest of the team adopt them. So when the JD said Ninja Van wants people 'brimming with ideas who take initiative rather than wait to be told' — that genuinely reads like how I already work."

**If she probes team-first / unglamorous work:**

"I'm also happy doing the glue work, not just shiny features — some of my proudest work was owning release engineering for four CLIs, automating our docs, and fixing flaky cross-platform tests so the whole team shipped safer."

**Lands because:** every claim is real (self-taught AI + taught the team, Go-from-zero — straight from your recommendations) and echoes their exact JD language.

## 2) Motivations

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**Likely:** "What motivates you?" · "Why are you looking?" · "Why this role?"

**What motivates you:**

"Two things. First, building and learning for its own sake — I build side projects for fun; I recently built a real-time multiplayer game end to end in four days just to learn a new game server and WebSockets, and I contribute to open source because I like shipping things people actually use. Second, impact I can see. At Turbot my work protected enterprise systems, which I loved — but Ninja Van's scale is so tangible: 2 million parcels and 250 million API requests a day. Writing backend systems that directly move that kind of real-world volume is genuinely exciting."

## Why looking (forward-looking frame — never badmouth Turbot):

"After nearly four years at Turbot — growing from intern to shipping production services and owning open-source releases — I'm ready for my next challenge, ideally somewhere I can build at the ground level. What draws me to Ninja Van specifically is exactly that: I've done greenfield work, I helped build Turbot Guardrails from scratch, and helping lay the foundations and shape the engineering culture of a brand-new India lab is the 0-to-1 opportunity I want next."

**Lands because:** intrinsic-builder proof (side projects + OSS), a scale/impact motivation specific to *them*, and the founding-team tie-in is the "Why Ninja Van specifically" they explicitly test. **If asked point-blank "why did you leave?"** give the real reason in one honest sentence, then pivot straight back to the forward-looking draw above.

### 3) More about the role & Ninja Van

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#### Show understanding + excitement:

"From what I've read, this is a full-stack role on the new India tech lab — a Go and Node.js backend with a React/TypeScript front end, which lines up almost exactly with my stack; Go is my primary language and where I want to go deeper. I also know you run a large microservices architecture on GKE — around 200 services — with Kafka pipelines and MySQL/TiDB, and that you deploy close to daily. Honestly the founding-team framing is the biggest draw: getting in early enough to influence architecture and standards, not just pick up tickets."

#### Then ask (pick 2–3 — genuine curiosity is a top culture signal here):

- "What are the first systems the India lab will own — fully greenfield, or taking over services from Singapore HQ?"
- "How big is the India team today, and what's the growth plan over the next 6–12 months?"
- "For new services, is Go the direction, or is it a mix of Go and Java/Play across teams?"
- "What does day-to-day collaboration between the India lab and the Singapore org look like?"
- "Is the role hybrid — what's the office expectation?" (*also cleanly surfaces location logistics*)

**Lands because:** the real facts (GKE / ~200 services / Kafka / TiDB / daily deploys) prove you did the work, and founding-team-savvy questions read as ownership, not passivity.

### 4) Salary expectations

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**Strategy:** enthusiasm first → invite *their* band → if pushed, give a market-anchored range tied to your current comp → signal flexibility. Never refuse (reads evasive); never anchor blind-low.

"I'll be upfront — the role and team are my priority; I'm optimizing for the right opportunity, not just a number. That said, my last CTC was ₹14 LPA — ₹11 lakh fixed plus ₹3 lakh variable — and for this role I'm looking for around ₹18 LPA. Since the fit looks strong, I'm flexible on the structure, and I'd genuinely welcome hearing the band you've budgeted so we can land on a number that works for both of us. I'm also available to join immediately."

### Salary notes (for you — don't recite):

- Your ask: **₹18 LPA on a ₹14 LPA last CTC** (₹11 fixed + ₹3 variable) = a ~29% hike — healthy and standard, and right around the market median (**levels.fyi** ≈ **₹18.4L** for this profile), so it's easy to justify.
  - Push for a stronger **fixed** component: within an ₹18L CTC, aim for fixed around **₹15–16L** (your current fixed is ₹11L) so more of the offer is guaranteed rather than variable.
  - **Available immediately** — say it; for a founding team that wants to move fast, it's a genuine advantage. If they counter low, hold near ₹17–18L and lean on the fit + your open-source track record.
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### Recruiter-screen meta (quick)

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- Keep each answer **~30–60s**; stop and let her steer. Warmth + clarity beat completeness.
- **Never** badmouth Turbot — neutral/positive framing only.
- Have **"Why Ninja Van"** crisp — it's the make-or-break question here.
- Close by cleanly confirming the logistics she needs: **location/hybrid, notice/availability, comp** — recruiters advance the candidates who make their job easy.